

uncertain whether I've got anything more to add," he muses. Dalrymple tantalises by toying with the idea of a family memoir that involves his extraordinary Franco-Bengali relations. And another good story he's earmarked. "It's a sort of White Mughal set in the early Ottoman Empire about an English aristocrat who bought himself into the Ottoman system, took on Oliver Cromwell's Company in the Mediterranean successfully, but was later captured and executed at the Tower of London," says the historian, confessing, "I love when you can find tight little personal stories that feel as exciting as fiction."

The author, who will turn 60 in 2025, believes these books should keep him busy for the next 20 years. And be it writing, organising the Jaipur Literature Festival, doing book tours or travelling, he wouldn't change much about his life. "If I was to win the lottery tomorrow, I might buy a nice house somewhere in the sun, but I don't think I'd change my modus operandi at all. I already do what I love, what gives me most pleasure and satisfaction," he smiles. ■

–Priya Pathiyan



History Books 2024

Past Perfect

***T.C.A. Raghavan** shares his pick of the best history reads of the year gone by*

It was an excellent year for readable history books. I admired the sweep of Manu Pillai's *Gods, Guns and Missionaries* (Penguin). Looking at its voluminous footnotes gives a sense of how a popular historian can base himself on the latest academic work, do primary research and write a compelling narrative.

I enjoyed A.R. Venkatachalapathy's *Swadeshi Steam* (Penguin), which made the story of a steamship company into a gripping drama of nationalism vs colonialism. It demonstrates that economic history need not be dull but can be a page turner in the hands of a skilled historian.

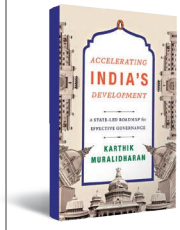
I was rivetted by the history of a murder mystery in Karachi in 1970–71. *Society Girl* by Saba Imtiaz and Tooba Masood-Khan (Roli). This is a deep dive into the extant written and oral archive to investigate how a suicide became a murder case because of the scandal arising from an adultery angle. Illicit sex in high society makes news and the power of popular perception impacts the police investigation. Probing the 'murder' becomes almost a social history of Pakistan with the public mesmerised by this story of sex and homicide even as the country hurtles towards its disastrous breakup in December 1971.

The year 2024 was also a great one for historical biography in India. I greatly liked *Camille Bulcke: The Jesuit Exponent of Ramkatha*, the biography of the Jesuit priest and Hindi scholar by Ravi Dutt Bajpai and Swati Parashar (Cambridge University Press).

Avinash Paliwal's *India's Near East* (Penguin) is situated at the intersection of diplomatic history and India's domestic politics, and this exploration of our more recent history had me engaged. To me it not just underlines the fragility of our eastern frontiers but also how much more work needs to be done to advance our understanding of the region.

In addition to these, I wait eagerly for Anirudh Kanisetti's forthcoming book on the Cholas (Juggernaut).

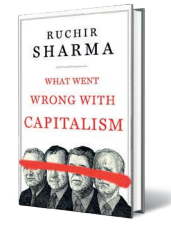
ECONOMICS BOOKS 2024



ACCELERATING INDIA'S DEVELOPMENT
A State-Led Roadmap for Effective Governance
By Karthik Muralidharan
PENGUIN VIKING
₹1,299; 832 pages

With 20 years of experience in teaching and research on policymaking and governance, the author delves deep into key sectors like education, health, public safety and the justice system to offer tangible ideas that can improve the functioning of the Indian state. While it is rooted in economics, it includes insights and perspectives from a range of disciplines like politics, sociology, psychology and management. Written with a general reader in mind, it is easy to comprehend and relate to.

–M.G. Arun



WHAT WENT WRONG WITH CAPITALISM
By Ruchir Sharma
ALLEN LANE
₹999; 384 pages

Don't worry, the celebrity investment banker and columnist Ruchir Sharma isn't giving up on capitalism—he's just ticked off with governments tampering with the economy, particularly in the form of low interest rates, 'cheap money' and the 'socialisation of risk'. He would like to see less tinkering and wishes governments would stop treating the economy like a machine and more like 'a complex organism' or a 'natural ecosystem'.